

AUBAINE



PLAYER HANDBOOK

BOOK • V0.2.1

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THE THREE GOLDEN RULES

Aubaine rests on three golden rules. They come before every other rule, including the ones in this book, and every page that follows answers to them.

THE THREE GOLDEN RULES

1. **The Rule of Cool.** In Aubaine, anything cool is allowed, even when it bends the fiction or a rule. Cool prevails. But the Uncool is never Cool.
2. **The Rule of Customisation.** Players and GMs are welcome to change Skills, items and anything else to give each player a unique experience and let them play whatever they want. Renaming a Skill and changing its damage type and Domain to fit a frost wizard is no problem at all, as long as the player honours the third rule.
3. **The Rule of Good Faith.** GMs and players are all here to play and enjoy Aubaine. A player who abuses Aubaine's fiction-first philosophy, or the kindness of their GM, has no place at a roleplaying table. Dressing something up as cool just to min-max your character is Uncool.

COOL

The first rule gives the table the right to put a great scene ahead of the letter of a rule. An impossible leap from a balcony, a line that turns a duel around, an idea nobody saw coming: if the whole table finds it cool, it happens, and the GM works out how to resolve it.

Cool is judged by the whole table; one player's excitement is not enough. Whatever spoils the evening for the others, flattens someone else's character or breaks the tone the table agreed on is not cool, and the rule does not cover it.

CUSTOMISATION

Nothing in Aubaine is set in stone. A Skill can change its name, its damage type or its Domain to suit the character you want to play, and an item can take another shape or another story. The GM approves each change, and the character sheet records it.

The more a change touches what a Skill does at the table, its power or its price, the more the third rule weighs on the decision.

GOOD FAITH

The third rule guards the other two. Cool and customisation both rest on trust between players and GM, and that trust does not survive abuse.

A player acting in good faith suggests an idea because it makes the scene better. A player acting in bad faith hunts for loopholes, dresses up an optimisation as a cool idea, or wears the GM down until they give in.

When in doubt, ask yourself one question: would what I am asking for make the game better for everyone?

WELCOME TO AUBAINE

Aubaine is a tabletop roleplaying game, a TTRPG to its friends. One person, the GM, describes a world and everything in it. Everyone else plays one character each, decides what that character does, and the whole table finds out together what happens next. The story takes shape as you play, session after session, and nobody knows in advance where it will lead.

This chapter and the next are enough to sit down at a table.

WHAT HAPPENS AT A TABLE

A game is a conversation with dice in it, and it runs on a simple loop.

1. **The GM describes a situation.** What the characters see and hear, what threatens them, what tempts them.
2. **You say what your character does.** You speak for them, in their words or your own.
3. **The GM says what happens.** When the outcome is certain, they narrate it. When it is uncertain and failure would cost something, a **Roll** decides.

Then the situation has changed, and the loop starts again. It turns the same way for searching a cupboard, a tense negotiation or a duel on the edge of a cliff.

AN EXAMPLE OF PLAY

GM: “The rope bridge sways over the ravine. Halfway across, three planks have given way, and the drop is waiting for you below.”

Sélène’s player: “I take a run-up and jump the gap.”

GM: “The outcome is uncertain, and a fall would cost you dearly. Make a **Dexterity + Acrobatics** Roll against DC 15.”

The player rolls two d12s and gets a 7 and a 9. Sélène has +3 in Dexterity and nothing in Acrobatics, so her total is 19, over the DC.

GM: “You land on the far side with a creak of rope. Behind you, another plank comes loose and tumbles for a long time before the mist swallows it.”

WHO DOES WHAT

The GM

The game master. They describe the world, play everything that is not a player character, set the difficulty of what you attempt and rule on whatever the rules leave open. They are not playing against you: their job is to make the world feel alive and your choices matter.

The players

Each runs one character, decides what it does and speaks for it. You decide what your character attempts; the GM and the dice decide how it turns out.

The table

All of you, together. The table decides the tone of the game, what belongs in the fiction and what does not. Those conversations happen outside the game, before the first session and whenever they are needed, and they matter more than any rule.

WHAT YOU NEED

- A character sheet.

HOW TO PLAY

Anything uncertain in Aubaine is settled by a **Roll**, and a Roll is always the same sum:

2d12 + a **Characteristic** + an **Aptitude**

This formula serves everywhere: an attack, a dodge, a lie and an afternoon at the forge all resolve this way. What changes from one situation to the next is the pair you use and the number you need.

WHEN TO ROLL

You do not roll for everything. A Roll takes time at the table, so it should decide something.

1. **Describe.** Say what your character wants and how they go about it.
2. **Roll.** If the outcome is uncertain and failure would cost something, the GM asks for a Roll.
3. **Resolve.** The result settles it, and the situation moves on.

An action whose outcome is certain simply succeeds: opening an unlocked door, climbing a ladder, buying bread. An action the fiction makes impossible needs no Roll either: it fails. Everything in between, you roll.

Your **Gift** moves that line for you alone. Someone with the Gift of speaking to the dead can question a corpse nobody else could make talk, and the GM decides what the dead one answers.

CHOOSING THE PAIR

The GM picks the pair from how you act, and every combination of **Characteristic** and **Aptitude** is open.

That keeps you useful far from your strengths. A character built on **Strength** intimidates by smashing a table rather than raising their voice, and the Roll becomes **Strength + Intimidation**. A character who relies on **Intelligence** gets past a physical obstacle by understanding it, and the Roll becomes **Intelligence + Athletics**.

It also gives you a floor. Without the **Aptitude** you would want, you still have your **Characteristic**: nobody rolls bare dice.

EXAMPLE

The party needs a ferryman to take them across at night. Aldric, a giant of a man with no gift for words, lays his axe on the table and stares at the ferryman in silence. The GM asks for a **Strength + Intimidation Roll**. His companion would rather open her purse and haggle, so for her it is **Charisma + Persuasion**. Two approaches, two pairs, and each has its chance.

Your **Speciality** enters the pair whenever the action falls within its field: it takes the **Aptitude's** place and adds 1 **Advantage** to the Roll. A “Traps” Speciality serves to disarm a trapped flagstone, a “Cooking” one to recognise poison in a stew. The Creating a character chapter presents it with the rest of the **Soul**.

A Skill can set its own pair. When it does, its text names it.

NAMING A ROLL

There are two ways to write it, depending on what the rule needs to pin down.

- A **Melee Roll**, when only the **Aptitude** matters and the **Characteristic** follows how you act.
- A **Strength + Melee Roll**, when the whole pair is fixed.

AGAINST WHAT

The total is compared with one of three defences.

DC

A Difficulty Class, set by the GM or printed in a rule.

AC

Armour Class, when an **Attack** targets a creature directly.

Opposed Roll

The Roll of the creature on the other side. Both sides roll.

CREATING A CHARACTER

Creating a character takes eight steps, in order. The first seven are decisions, the last is arithmetic. Do not fill in a single numbered box before step 8: a character is imagined first and counted afterwards.

Take your time over the early steps. Who is this character, where do they come from, what drives them onto the road: the answers will guide every number you write down later.

WHAT THE GM GIVES YOU

A new character receives:

- one Domain Tree;
- one Archetype Tree;
- two Species Skills;
- 25 Experience Points (XP);
- 22 Mastery Points (MP);
- 3 Potential Points (PP).

The GM announces any change to that set before the table starts. A one-evening game and a long campaign do not open on the same numbers.

THREE CURRENCIES

They do not convert into one another. A currency spent in the wrong place is only recovered in play.

XP

Buys Trees, Skills and their Levels.

MP

Buys the six **Characteristics**, the **Aptitudes** and the **Speciality**.

PP

Buys the three resource paths: **Vitality**, **Memory** and **Energy**.

THE ORDER OF THE STEPS

1. **Species, Archetype, Domain.** Choose them from what the GM offers, and your subspecies or regional origin where the Species has any. They fix your first two Trees, your two Species Skills and your **Speed**.
2. **The Soul.** Write down the **Phobia**, the **Mania**, the **Flaw**, the **Speciality** and the **Gift**.

3. **Characteristics.** Spend MP.

4. **Aptitudes and Speciality.** Spend MP.

5. **Resources.** Place the 3 PP.

6. **Skills.** Spend the 25 XP in your Trees.

7. **Equipment.** Fill the eight worn slots.

8. **Derived values.** Work out **HP**, **Memory**, **Energy**, **AC**, **Speed** and **Initiative**.

A step can be replayed as long as nobody has rolled a die. After the first **Roll** of the first session the sheet is fixed, and progression takes over.

The Species chapter covers step 1 in detail, and the Trees and Skills chapter covers step 6.

THE SOUL

The Soul is what sets a character apart once the numbers are equal. It is decided with the GM, in whatever tone the table has set for itself.

Every character carries five pieces of it.

Phobia

A fear that weighs on their decisions. It earns its place when it costs something.

Mania

A habit, an obsession, a gesture that keeps coming back.

Flaw

A lasting trait that draws trouble towards them.

Speciality

A narrow personal field they excel in.

Gift

An exceptional faculty that belongs to them alone.

The first three make the character's life harder and earn them **Karma**. The last two say what they can do like nobody else at the table.

KARMA

The Phobia, the Mania and the Flaw each carry a Karma slot. A character therefore holds at most three points, one per slot.

SPECIES

Your Species is the first of the three choices in step 1, alongside your Archetype and your Domain. It says where your character comes from, in body and in history: the elf at the foot of her world-tree, the human who came ashore from a lost continent, the dead whom death did not keep.

WHAT A SPECIES GIVES YOU

It brings two things to creation:

- **two Species Skills**, chosen from those your Species and, if you have one, your subspecies or regional origin offer or impose. They are **Memorised** without taking up any **Memory** and need not be bought. Once creation is over, you cannot change them;
- **your Speed**, when it differs from the default 9 metres.

Both come free. They cost neither XP nor MP, and they do not count against the 22 MP or the 25 XP the GM gives you.

A Species also sets your **Size**, and it can name the languages you speak, read and write.

CHOOSING TWO SKILLS

A Species usually offers more Skills than it grants. You keep two at creation, and that choice already says what kind of member of your Species you are.

The others are not lost: you can buy them later from the **Common Bank**, at the price printed on each Skill, and their **Prerequisite** keeps them for your Species. A Species Skill bought this way is Memorised like any other and takes 1 Memory while it is Memorised.

EXAMPLE

A player creates an elf scout. From the Skills the Elf Species offers, she keeps [Keen Senses](#) and [Elven Meditation](#). A few sessions later, she buys [Nature's Cover](#) from the Common Bank. That one takes 1 Memory when she Memorises it; the first two take none.

So two characters of the same Species do not start with the same gifts. A Species that offers only two Skills leaves no choice: you take both.

SUBSPECIES AND REGIONAL ORIGINS

Some Species divide into subspecies, shown on the Species page. A few call them regional origins: both names mean the same thing, and each page uses its own Species' word. You choose yours at creation, and you then keep your two Skills from those of your Species and your subspecies.

A subspecies can impose one of those two Skills, and the Species page marks it as imposed. You take it automatically, and choose the second from the other Skills of your Species and your subspecies.

A subspecies' Skills carry that subspecies as their Prerequisite. A character of another subspecies cannot buy them.

SPECIES THAT BORROW FROM ANOTHER

Some Species take part of what they are from another Species: an Undead keeps the body of the Species it was in life, and a Scothan takes theirs from one of their two parents. Their page says which to choose and what you take from it, such as Size, Speed or languages.

For any Prerequisite, such a character also counts as a member of the Species they take those traits from, when their page says so.

PLAYING YOUR SPECIES

Each Species page tells its history, its customs and how other peoples see it. A "Playing" table gives the landmarks of a character of that Species: the age of adulthood, the lifespan, the usual height and the languages.

Nothing forces your character to be what their people expect. An elf who hates the forest, a human who has turned her back on the guilds: a character who strays from their Species often has

TREES AND SKILLS

Your XP goes almost entirely into your Trees. A Tree is a grid of Skills joined by lines, with the Skill at its centre as its heart. You enter a Tree through its heart, then move outwards line by line.

You start with two Trees, one Archetype and one Domain. The Archetype says how your character acts; the Domain says with what. A Berserker and a Marchand are two Archetypes; Feu and Terre are two Domains. These are only examples: the list of published Trees lives and changes, and the trees index carries it.

Every Tree can be downloaded from its page, ready to print. When a Tree changes, its printable version changes with it.

UNLOCKING A TREE

During play you can unlock more Trees, Archetypes and Domains alike. Unlocking a Tree costs 5 XP per Tree you already have: a third Tree costs 10 XP, a fourth 15 XP, and so on. Once unlocked, a Tree sells its Skills just like your first two.

READING A TREE

Every node is a Skill, and its shape gives its type: a circle for an active Skill, a rounded square for a passive one, a concave shape for a special one.

The border carries the Skill's Domain or Domains, and that is what gives it its colour. A Skill with no Domain is Neutral. The gold token carries its price in XP.

The lines join each node to its neighbours. They mark the path you follow through the Tree.

BUYING A SKILL

Each Skill costs 5 to 100 XP, in steps of 5, and its price is printed on it. To buy it in a Tree, you also need to be able to reach it.

- **The heart first.** The first Skill you buy in a Tree is its heart, at the centre.
- **Line by line.** After that, you can buy any Skill joined by a line to a Skill of that Tree you have

already **Learned**.

A Learned Skill opens its neighbours wherever it came from: a purchase in that Tree, the **Common Bank**, or another Skill that gave it to you.

EXAMPLE

In the Feu Tree, you start with [Aviver les flammes](#), its heart. [Trait de feu](#), joined to the heart, then becomes available, and after it [Boule de Feu](#), joined to [Trait de feu](#).

If your character learned [Trait de feu](#) from the Common Bank before unlocking the Feu Tree, they do not buy it again, and [Boule de Feu](#) is open to them from the moment they unlock the Tree.

LEARNING AND MEMORISING

Buying a Skill means learning it, not **memorising** it. A Learned Skill is yours for good. What is limited is how many you can carry at once, and your **Memory** is what says so.

A Memorised Skill is a Skill you carry and can play. It takes 1 Memory, except in the cases listed under "Where your Memory goes".

A Skill is learned only once, whether it came to you from a purchase, from your Species or from another Skill. If a Tree you unlock sells a Skill that is already Learned, you do not buy it again: it counts as bought in that Tree, and it opens its neighbours like any other.

LEVELS

Some Skills carry Levels, bought separately and in order. A Level is not a new Skill: it is the same one, doing more.

A Memorised Skill takes 1 Memory whatever its Level. Raising a Skill therefore never costs you room, only XP.

Some Skills give rise to another, more specialised one, which appears as its own node joined to its base. It is bought like the others, once its base is Learned.

BASIC SKILLS

Some Skills belong to nobody. Every creature has them, from the first round of the first session to the end of the campaign. They cost no XP, take up no **Memory**, ask for no **Energy**, and no Tree sells them.

Together they make the list of what anyone can always attempt, with or without a Tree: [Attaquer](#), [Courir](#), [Se cacher](#), [Aider](#), [Esquiver](#) and the others. The Skills index carries the full list.

READING AN ENTRY

They read like the Skills in your Trees: the name, then what the Skill takes to play, its range and its duration, then its rule. They carry no price and no box to tick, since there is nothing to buy and nothing to **memorise**.

An entry marked “1 **Attack**” is not played on its own: it replaces one of the Attacks of the [Attaquer](#) action. That is the case for manoeuvres such as [Bousculer](#) and [Agripper](#), which knock down or hold an opponent instead of wounding them.

WHAT THEY COVER

Most of them serve in combat. There is something to strike with, something to defend with and something to get away with: [Esquiver](#) makes you harder to hit, [Se désengager](#) lets you leave an opponent without offering an [Attaque d'opportunité](#), and [Se préparer](#) holds an action back for the moment something happens.

Others serve everywhere. [Se cacher](#) and [Chercher](#) work against each other, in an alley as much as on a battlefield, and [Aider](#) gives a hand to an ally attempting something you could do yourself.

IMPROVISING

The list opens with [Improviser](#), which covers whatever the others do not.

When nothing covers what you are attempting, say what your character wants and how they go about it. The GM answers three things: whether it

is possible, what the attempt costs and risks, and which **Roll** settles it.

EXAMPLE

Player: “I throw my knife at the chandelier’s rope, so it comes down on the guards.”

GM: “You can, and it takes your **Action**. Make a **Dexterity + Aim** Roll to cut the rope at the right moment. If you succeed, the guards underneath make a **Dexterity + Reflexes** Roll against your **DC**, or they are knocked **À terre**.”

This list is not closed. It describes what tables do most often; anything the fiction allows plays out the same way, and the Rule of Cool counts here more than anywhere.

EQUIPMENT

A creature wears eight pieces of equipment at once, one per slot. A piece does nothing until it is worn: nothing applies from a backpack.

Most of what you wear, you will have made yourself. Shops exist, but Aubaine routes your equipment through the materials you bring back, the recipes you follow and the **Rolls** you succeed on.

WEARING A PIECE

A piece can carry a **Prerequisite**, printed under its name. Only a creature that meets it can equip it.

Skills granted by a worn piece take up no **Memory** and do not have to be learned. The piece grants them while it is worn, and takes them back the moment you remove it.

Each catalogue entry prints what concerns it: its headline value, its stats, its named properties, its recipe and what it grants. Those numbers belong to the piece and are not repeated anywhere else.

THE SLOTS

Head

Helm, hood, crown. Whatever protects or marks the face.

Torso

The piece that carries your Armour Class formula. One at a time.

Boots

Hose and greaves: whatever touches the ground and sets your **Speed**.

Necklace

Torque, amulet, pendant. Worn against the skin, under the armour.

One hand (x2)

One slot per hand. A weapon, a shield or nothing in each. A two-handed weapon takes both. You choose which hand holds what.

Jewel (x2)

Two independent slots. Ring, set stone, carved talisman.

The GM tells you what you start with. With no armour, your **AC** is $12 + \text{Dexterity}$, and an unarmed Strike deals $1d4 + \text{Strength}$: a character with nothing is never defenceless.

FINDING MATERIALS

What you can wear depends on the materials you bring back.

After a significant encounter, or on finding a source worth working, each character receives a **Loot Opportunity**. Spend it in one of these two ways, never both.

Random loot

Roll the source's **Loot Die**. The GM reads its **Loot Table** and tells you what you get. No further Roll.

Targeted harvest

Say what you are after and how you get it. The GM sets the Roll and its **DC**. On a failure, the **Opportunity** is spent for nothing.

The first choice is safe and asks nothing of you. The second aims true and may come back empty. A target the fiction does not let you extract cannot be won with a Roll: you do not harvest scales from a beast that has none.

READING A MATERIAL

A material has a name, one or more **Types** and a **Material Value**. For example: Wolf pelt, **Types** Leather and Beast, **Value** 1.

In a single piece of crafting, a material counts for only one of its **Types**, even if it carries several the recipe accepts.

The **Material Value** works twice: it counts towards a recipe's cost, and a material sold back brings in its **Value** in silver coins.

CRAFTING

An entry's recipe box names its discipline, its cost, the **Types** it accepts and its **Rolls** in order.

1. Gather materials that cover each of the **Types** asked for.

EXPLORATION

Combat is the most detailed part of the game. Most of a game, though, is spent exploring: a crypt to search, a forest to cross, a door nobody dares to open. All of it runs on the ordinary loop. You describe what you do, the GM sets a **Roll** and a **DC** when one is needed, and the result settles it.

This chapter gathers the rules for the situations that come up at every table.

Your **Gift** and your **Speciality** often find their place here. A Gift for speaking to the dead gets the skeleton in a crypt to testify, a Gift of premonitions can warn you of the corridor about to give way, and a “Traps”, “Navigation” or “Monsters” Speciality enters the Rolls these places call for.

SEEING AND BEING SEEN

Much of what an adventurer attempts depends on what they can see: spotting danger, aiming at a target, reading an inscription. Light, and whatever gets in the way of sight, changes the Rolls.

LIGHT

Bright light

Full daylight, an overcast sky, the circle of a torch or a campfire. You see normally.

Dim light

Dawn, dusk, a full moon, the edge of bright light fading into the dark. You see poorly.

Darkness

A moonless night, the back of a cave, a room with the shutters closed. You see nothing.

VISIBILITY

Reduced visibility

In dim light, a light fog or thick foliage, Rolls that depend on sight, such as most **Perception** Rolls, take 1 **Disadvantage**.

No visibility

In darkness, a thick fog or opaque smoke, you see nothing that is inside it. For anything you try to see in that area, you are **Aveuglé**.

Some Skills and some Species let you see where others see nothing. Their text says exactly what they change.

HIDING AND SEARCHING

To slip out of sight, use [Se cacher](#). You need something to hide behind: cover, shadow, the back of a creature busy with something else. The GM says whether the situation allows it. On a success, you gain **Caché** against the creatures you fooled.

To flush out a hidden creature, or find something that eludes you, use [Chercher](#). A secret passage, a trap or a clue can be found as long as you search in the right place: if you search far from what is hidden, no result reveals it.

EXAMPLE

The party is searching a necromancer’s library. Sélène’s player says she is examining the shelves at the back, where the dust is missing. The GM asks for a **Spirit** + **Perception** Roll against DC 20. She succeeds: one book sounds hollow when she pulls it, and the shelf swings open. Another player, who was searching the desk, would have found nothing whatever they rolled.

TRAVEL

Over an adventure, characters cover long distances, across hours or days. The GM can sum up a journey in a few sentences, or play it step by step when the road matters.

PACE

Outside combat, a group chooses its pace. It sets the distance covered and what the group notices along the way.

SOCIAL INTERACTION

Over your adventures you will meet people far more often than monsters, and plenty of monsters would rather talk than fight. Talking a ferryman round, prising a name out of an informant, calming a crowd or fooling a guard: these scenes are played by talking first, and the dice only come in when the outcome is still uncertain.

The GM plays every creature that is not a player character. They give each one a personality, wants and fears, and decide how it reacts from those.

PLAYING THE SCENE

You can speak for your character in their own words, or describe what they say and how they say it. Both are equally good. What matters is what your character offers, asks for or threatens, and to whom.

A creature reacts to what it is offered and to what you touch in it. A cowardly bandit gives in sooner to the threat of the noose. A busy merchant will not help people who waste her time. A vain noble opens up to flattery. Listen to how the GM plays their characters: what they let slip often tells you how to handle them.

ATTITUDE

Every creature has an attitude towards you, which the GM sets at the start of the scene.

Friendly

It looks on you kindly and leans towards helping. Your **Rolls** to influence it gain 1 **Advantage**.

Indifferent

It wants neither to help you nor to harm you. This is a stranger's default attitude.

Hostile

It looks on you badly and leans towards harming you. Your **Rolls** to influence it take 1 **Disadvantage**.

Attitude shifts with what happens in the scene. A favour done, an insult, a promise kept or broken moves it, and the GM tells you when it changes.

INFLUENCING A CREATURE

When you want something from a creature, describe how you go about it: you persuade it, lie to it, threaten it, entertain it. The GM then judges where it stands.

Willing

What you ask already goes its way. It agrees, with no **Roll**, in its own fashion.

Unwilling

What you ask repels it or goes against what it is. It refuses, with no **Roll**. No speech makes a loyal man betray his family.

Hesitant

It might agree, but nothing is settled. You make a **Roll**.

The GM picks the pair from your approach: **Persuasion** to convince in good faith, **Deception** to lie, **Intimidation** to threaten, **Performance** to win it over with a show, **Animal Handling** for an animal. The **Characteristic** follows how you act, as everywhere else.

A **Speciality** that covers what you are doing, such as "Trade" for haggling, enters the **Roll** in place of those **Aptitudes** and adds 1 **Advantage** to it.

The **DC** is 15 by default, and the GM moves it along the difficulty scale depending on what you ask. When the creature actively pushes back, against a lie it suspects or a threat it wants to defy, the **Roll** becomes opposed: its **Spirit** + **Insight** against your lie, its **Spirit** + **Will** against your threat.

On a success, the creature does what you ask. On a failure, it does not give way, and the same request made the same way fails again. You need to change something to try again: a new argument, a new offer, someone else to talk to, or time, usually a day.

COMBAT

Combat has no resolution rules of its own: you roll the same **Rolls** as anywhere else. What it adds is an order to act in and a budget for each turn, so that everyone gets their go when everything is happening at once.

HOW A FIGHT UNFOLDS

A fight is split into rounds. A round lasts about 6 seconds, long enough for every creature to take its turn.

1. **Positions.** The GM describes where the creatures are and what surrounds them. The players say where their characters are.
2. **Surprise.** The GM says whether anyone is surprised.
3. **Initiative.** Everyone rolls initiative, which sets the order of turns.
4. **Turns.** Each creature takes its turn in that order.
5. **The next round.** Once everyone has acted, a new round begins, in the same order, until the fight ends.

SURPRISE

When one side runs into the other without seeing it coming, a successful ambush for instance, the GM declares surprised the creatures that did not expect it.

In the first round, a surprised creature takes its turn after every creature that is not surprised, in the order of their initiatives. It cannot use any **Reaction** until the end of that first turn.

INITIATIVE

At the start of a fight, each player character rolls:

1d4 + Dexterity

You act from the highest result to the lowest. Players win ties against their opponents, and settle ties among themselves however they like.

The die is small on purpose. A gap in **Dexterity** weighs heavily in this order, more than in any other Roll in the game.

The order holds for the whole fight. You do not roll it again each round.

TWO VARIANTS

The GM can roll once for a group of identical creatures, and separately for each major one. It shortens a fight with many opponents without changing any rule.

They can also merge allied positions that follow one another with no opponent in between. Allies in the same block then weave their movement and actions together. Each keeps their own start and end of turn, which matters for anything that triggers there, and Reactions interrupt as usual.

YOUR TURN

On your turn, you have four things. They are independent: not using one does not give you another.

An Action

Most Skills are played with one, starting with [Attaquer](#).

A Bonus Action

A quick action, reserved for Skills that say so. It does not replace the Action, and nothing converts it.

Movement

Up to your **Speed**, 9 metres unless your Species sets another. You can spread it freely before, during and after your actions.

A Reaction

Outside your turn, when a rule gives you a trigger. It comes back at the start of your next turn.

DAMAGE AND HEALING

HP measure how much a creature can take before it falls. Damage brings them down, healing and rest bring them back up, and when they reach 0, a race against death begins.

HP

Your maximum HP is worked out at creation and rises with your Vitality, as the Creating a character chapter explains. Your current HP go down when you take damage and back up when you are healed.

They never go above your maximum and never below 0.

DAMAGE

A Skill, a weapon or a danger that wounds states its damage: dice, sometimes a fixed number, often both. An **Attack** always adds the **Characteristic** its **Roll** used.

Damage can carry a type, such as Bludgeoning, Fire or Acid damage. A weapon prints its own, and a Skill names it when its damage carries one. The type matters when a creature resists it or is vulnerable to it, or when a rule names it.

RESISTANCE AND VULNERABILITY

A creature can have a resistance or a vulnerability to a damage type, to a source of damage, or to all damage, typed or not.

Resistance

It takes half the damage concerned, rounded down.

Vulnerability

It takes double.

Neither calls for a Roll: they apply to the total, once the dice are rolled. When other rules change the same damage, go in this order:

1. Total the damage with anything that raises or lowers it by a fixed number, such as an Attack's Characteristic or "you take 1 less".
2. If the Skill only deals half, on a success for instance, halve that total, rounded down.

3. Halve the result for a resistance, or double it for a vulnerability.

When one blow deals damage of several types, a resistance or a vulnerability only touches the share of its own type. Anything added without naming a type, such as an Attack's Characteristic, counts with the weapon's or the Skill's damage. Anything that removes a fixed number without naming a type, such as "you take 1 less", comes off the largest share.

A resistance and a vulnerability to the same damage cancel out, and that damage does not change. A resistance from two sources applies only once, following the same-effect-twice principle in the How to play chapter, and so does a vulnerability. Two resistances and one vulnerability to the same damage therefore still cancel out.

EXAMPLE

A 10-point Bludgeoning blow hits a creature that takes 1 less and has resistance to Bludgeoning damage. Take off the 1 first, then halve: it takes 4, half of 9 rounded down. With a vulnerability instead, it would take 18.

Damage reduced to 0 does not count as damage taken. It triggers nothing that triggers on taking damage, and it does not lower the **Agonie** counter.

Some creatures are entirely beyond an effect's reach: an Undead cannot be **Asleep**, for example. Their entry, or the state's, says so.

DROPPING TO 0 HP

When your HP drop to 0, you gain **Agonie** 3 and start dying.

The counter goes down by 1 at the end of each of your turns, but not on the turn you gained it: so you have three of your own turns before the end. Each enemy action that damages you costs you one more, once at most per action.

At 0, you die.

RESTING AND PROGRESSION

Between trials, two things recharge: your resources, through rest, and your character, through progression. They have nothing to do with each other. A rest refills your **Energy**; only progression makes you stronger.

THE SHORT REST

Ten minutes' pause, during which you can do something light: dress a wound, eat a bite, search the room. You can take at most two between **Long Rests**.

At the end, you recover:

- half your maximum **HP**, rounded down;
- half your maximum **Energy**, rounded down;
- the Skills marked "once per **Short Rest**".

It is half your maximum you recover, not half of what you are missing. You never go above your maximum.

EXAMPLE

Sélène comes out of a fight on 2 HP out of 29. After a Short Rest she recovers 14 HP, half of 29 rounded down, and climbs back to 16.

THE LONG REST

Eight hours of sleep. Two Long Rests must be at least sixteen hours apart, which allows one a day.

At the end, you recover all your HP, all your Energy, and the Skills marked "once per Short Rest" or "once per Long Rest".

A character who has not eaten or drunk enough that day recovers neither HP nor Energy, as the Exploration chapter explains.

WHAT A REST DOES NOT GIVE BACK

Karma

A point you hold stays, and an empty slot stays empty. Neither a rest nor the end of a session touches it.

Temporary HP

Healing does not restore them, and any left over disappear at the end of a rest.

CHANGING YOUR MEMORISED SKILLS

Both rests let you change the Skills your **Memory** holds, except your two Species Skills, fixed at creation. It is the only moment you rework what you carry.

That makes the Short Rest the group's real breathing space: ten minutes are enough to walk into the next fight with a different set of Skills, chosen from what you have seen of the danger.

THE EXPECTED RHYTHM

The game is tuned for five or six significant encounters between two Long Rests, with two Short Rests in between. Over a full cycle, the Energy available to you comes to about twice your maximum.

This rhythm is a design benchmark that every table adapts. A table that rests less plays more frugal characters, and the GM adjusts what they send at them.

PROGRESSION

A character grows through the three currencies of creation, which keep arriving separately. A fourth reward joins them in play: materials, recipes and equipment, which feed crafting.

The GM announces which one they are granting. They set the pace, and they are not bound to the same rhythm from one campaign to the next.

XP

The GM grants it when the group overcomes a significant obstacle, and everyone receives the same.

Overcoming does not mean defeating. Getting round it, talking your way through, containing it, escaping or solving it some other way all count as much as a won fight.

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